

Youssef Sawiris

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SMASH Hiring Team
Kapor Center · SMASH at UC Berkeley

Dear SMASH Hiring Team,

I am applying for the CS Instructor position at SMASH at UC Berkeley because the program is exactly the kind of door I wish more of my students could walk through. I am a sixth-grade math teacher at Lodestar Public Charter School in East Oakland, where I work with first-generation, low-income students of color — the same scholar community SMASH serves. I am also a former software engineer with two and a half years at Strava and currently consult on full-stack work for a multi-tenant SaaS, while pursuing my M.A. Education and California Teaching Credential at Reach University.

What I would bring to SMASH is a combination that is unusual in either direction: I have shipped production code at real scale — Strava Search (“Surtch”) re-indexed for 9B+ activities, a multi-tenant Stripe-billed SaaS, AI agents and MCP servers — and I spend every weekday in a classroom learning how eleven- and twelve-year-olds actually think about computational ideas. I know the difference between a polished slide and the moment a student stops staring at the wall and tries the problem again. My pedagogy at Lodestar leans on structured whole-class formative checks every lesson — mini-whiteboards, half-sheet quick-checks, and IM cool-downs — so confusion surfaces in real time and pacing adjusts. I differentiate aggressively, with IEP-aligned adaptations carried over from my prior special-education role at the same school.

For SMASH scholars, that posture matters. A five-week residential program is intense, the technical content stretches scholars, and a “just keep up” classroom default fails the students who would actually benefit most. I would bring a teacher-engineer who can both write the code at the level the curriculum demands and notice the scholar in the back row who has not asked for help in three days.

I would love to talk about what you are building this summer. I am in Oakland and reachable at 510.331.7772 or sawirisyoussef@gmail.com.

Sincerely,

Youssef Sawiris